

TEMPO



A Folk-Rock Musical

by David Quang Pham
based on the life of his grandma and her sister

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For My Midwest and Middle East Friends

SYNOPSIS

Set in modern times, this folk-rock world musical follows a struggling Midwestern musician who must fulfill their grandma's dying wish to reunite her with her sister, who went missing during a war long ago along with her music. In a fictional region known as The Middle, their search takes a turn when they meet a Middle Eastern poet, whose family sings their great aunt's songs at their temple. The dramedy explores themes of love and pain being temporary, life passing by at different rates, and music as a temple of memory and reconnections.

This story is inspired by David Quang Pham's grandma and great aunt, songwriting sisters. Grandma sold her guitar and they both gave up their dreams to survive poverty after the Vietnam War. Grandma stayed in Saigon while great aunt had gone nomad.

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PLOT SUMMARY

The musical presents plot developments in a non-linear narrative, but the plot summary details these events in chronological order.

Half a century ago, sisters Jessica and Lorenza were songwriters in an unnamed country. But war broke out, separating them (“Nothing Lasts”).

Today, Dakota, who goes by “Kota,” is a lonely musician barely making it in the Midwest. Upon hearing their grandma Jessica becoming gravely ill with dementia, they visit her home country for the first time. There, she shares the last photo of her and her sister Lorenza, respectively holding a guitar and notebook. She wishes to reconnect with her missing sister; that is if she is still alive (“Mama Wants, Mama Gets”).

Kota jots down what Jessica remembers of Lorenza’s lyrics. Kota asks the online community for help. Someone in the world recognizes these lyrics from their hometown in a region called The Middle. Kota and Jessica pay the city a visit (“The Lyrics Linger”).

With no leads, they hopelessly observe poet Tabitha do crowd work in the street. She is from the Middle East and goes by Tab. Tab asks for Kota’s full name. Kota’s middle-last name “F. Chéry” reminds Tab of “Hakol Efshari,” which in Hebrew means “Anything is Possible” (“אֶפְשָׁרִי”).

Tab invites Kota to a music poetry slam later that night. When the musician could not make it due to an injury, Kota steps in. With Tab, their chemistry engages the audience. The public starts knowing them as Tab and Kota, before establishing themselves as the Midwest-Middle Eastern duo, Tab and Coda (“Tab and Coda”).

During the holidays, Tab invites Kota and their grandma to their family’s temple. There, her parents sing their love duet (“In Loving Destiny”). Despite her dementia, Jessica recognizes Lorenza’s lyrics. She questions how they conceived the song. They claim every song is theirs (“Up to Speed”).

[Lorenza became a musical nomad after the war and ran away to their region. She would mentor Mar and Gveret Galili, where they fell in love

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during her class. When war loomed in the region, Lorenza asks the Galilis to never mention her and spread her peaceful songs, before disappearing once more. It turns out the Galilis were their longest protégés.]

The sisters never physically reunite. However, Jessica sees the folks Lorenza has touched with her poems and lyrics. Jessica passes away from dementia, finally forgetting the war and only remembering her sister's songs and that her grandchild Dakota found someone ("Her Songs Live On").

CAST OF CHARACTERS

DAKOTA F. CHÉRY is a lonely musician from the Midwest. They also go by Kota. For much of their life, they have minimal contact with their extended family. Their parents discourage them from visiting their motherland. But when their grandma's dementia becomes severe, Kota sets out to meet her for the first time and accomplish everything for her before she passes away.

TABITHA GALILI is a poet and oud player from the Middle East. She also goes by Tab. Her family runs a temple in the

JESSICA is Kota's grandma who was once a musician before she sold her guitar to survive poverty after the (unnamed) war. Upon the news of her terminal dementia, Dakota visits her (unnamed) country for the first time. While there, she wishes to reconnect with her missing sister before she passes away.

LORENZA is Jessica's sister who vanished during *the* war. She is unrelated to Tabitha's family but has ties to them. It is unknown if it is positive or negative.

JOSEPH is Dakota's cousin and translator. Depending on the production, they can go by Yosef or Yoosep.

GVERET GALILI is Tab's mother.

MAR GALILI is Tab's father.

MUSICAL NUMBERS

1. Nothing Lasts Jessica, Lorenza
2. Mama Wants, Mama Gets Jessica, Dakota
3. The Lyrics Lingers Dakota, Ensemble
4. [אֶפְשָׁרִי \(Efshari, Anything's Possible\)](#) Tabitha, Dakota, Residents
5. Tab and Coda Tabitha, Dakota
6. In Loving Destiny Gveret Galili, Mar Galili
7. Up to Speed Jessica, Gveret Galili, Mar Galili

POTENTIAL SONGS

Born in the Wrong Generation
Out of Tune
Future Plans
Right Person, Wrong Time
Keep Tabs (on Your Heart)
From the End
Slow Down
Life is Over Before You Know It
Her Songs Live On
Stand Fermata